

KATABEACHHOTELMATTHEWHINDMARCH

Travel Radio Australia and we are in Thailand. We're in a beautiful place, Phuket actually, and we have Matthew Heinbach, the Director of Hotel and Resorts, the Kata Sea Breeze Resort in Phuket, a beautiful property. Matthew, welcome to the program.

Thank you very much, lovely to be here. Now Matthew, tell us a bit about the Kata Sea Breeze, it looks like a magnificent property. Yes, Sea Breeze, it's actually a 330-room resort on Kata Beach, it's not too far away from the fabulous sands of Kata Beach.

Three and a half star, good value for money, that's what our slogan is, to make sure we give the best value of holidays we can to our guests who travel every year. It's 330 rooms, five swimming pools in total, three main restaurants as well, and for Australia, it's one of our top markets. You're very important to us, thank you very much for all your support and we look forward to welcoming you over the many years to come.

When you say three and a half star, I'm looking at this, it looks more like a four to five star place to me, it looks extremely luxurious. Look at that view you've got over the beach there, tell us about that view. The view, that's actually Kata Beach, that was taken by, on the telephone, it was not even taken on a professional camera, it was done by one of our team members.

Kata Beach, as a lot of you Australians will know, is one of the more popular beaches on the island. During the summer season, the monsoon season, then it becomes famous for surfing and this all came about during Covid, when us locals had nothing to do except enjoy the views and surfing became a popular after-work sport and since then the local hotels and the authorities of tourism have further developed and promoted it more for the off-season, which obviously for Australia is your wonderful high season. So you come opposite the direction from our friends here in Europe, but that view is pure sunset, we're on the sunset side of the island so we get some of the best views, okay, 6.45 every night, every day of the year, there's no time clock changes in Thailand, as you know, so it's a great time to relax, enjoy your sunset cocktails and mocktails and go with the flow, if you like.

So beautiful and tell us about the hotel itself, it sort of looks a bit modern, a bit traditional, a bit of a mix, right? Well Kata Seabreeze originally was built more on the Scandinavian design, chunky but simplistic, but offering good value for money, so we haven't got all the fabulous features of photographs and pictures and all the elegance of a five-star, but what we have got is excellent value for money, three and a half stars, very and very important, without all the fuss, so we keep things simple, the king beds for example, most of them now are seven foot, so it's quite a good size bed there, they've now all got smart TVs, as we all expect, we watch our own apps off our telephones, we have all that available, the five swimming pools are open till seven at night, we have a swimming pool bar, which in Australia is most, the most important thing of any good resort is to have a swimming pool bar, our happy hours are all day and all night, now we don't do for a

couple of hours, we were soon taught by our Australian friends that happy hours have to be all day and all night, so that's what we do, we follow the trend, okay, we have no fuss in the resort, we keep things as simple as we possibly can, family friendly, so we have a fabulous bunk bedroom that we developed and this actually came across from a family from Australia, who are very good friends of mine and over the past seven years, their two boys have grown up, they've got bigger and bigger and bigger and the famous hotel roll-away beds, the famous sofa roll-away beds and obviously got too small for the two boys, so I asked them what can we do and they came in and we had a look at one of the rooms, they said let's design some bunk beds, so the bunk beds are actually two beds built into the wall, they're not a standalone bunk bed and the beds are all six foot proper beds, you've got a proper mattress, not a silly flimsy thing and this was designed purely for the Australian families, we understand in Australia, you still class children at the age of 16, okay, so it's very important to offer product that's viable to sell in Australia and that's what we did, so we came with the bunk rooms and that's now 30 rooms, another popular room we have is the Agua Pura, which are pool access rooms, what we tend to find is Australians, you love your swimming bar but you love your pools, we have an awful lot of demand during the summer season for the pool access rooms and this is all coming from Australia, so it's all good business for us, we keep the resort as simple as we can, all the pricing we compare with local restaurants and bars, we do our best to ensure that we keep the pricing levels down, which means we tend to keep guests inside the resort, especially late afternoon, happy hours and happy hour, although it's all day after the beach and before they go out for dinner, so I always insist our prices, we can compete with the local market and I think that's where we've won an awful lot of business, we know Australians are very cautious about cleanliness in local restaurants and bars, obviously hotels, we have an extremely high international standard that we have to follow, which is another positive for us, so guests tend to compare, then they tend to stay in the resort in the evening, we have a pizza similar to a pizza in the resorts, the guests can cook, take a pizza, take it to the beach, take it to the pool, take it to the room as a grab-and-go scenario, you'll find now in Thailand hotels are becoming a lot more environmentally friendly, a lot more cautious about how we operate, so for example after breakfast we do all our room service, pool service as a grab-and-go scenario, all the packaging is eco-friendly, can all be recycled 100%, so it means we can actually close down the main washpot area of the hotel, which uses a lot of chemical obviously, we need that for breakfast because every day we're handling maybe 650 guests per morning, so we need to make sure everything's clean, but after breakfast we go grab-and-go, everything becomes environmentally friendly, which I know the Australian guests appreciate a lot, and another thing we've just started very recently, all the oil that oil we generate for breakfast and all the frying of the food, we now sell that onwards to a company that's developing biofuel for aircraft, they contacted me about three months ago, I didn't really quite believe this, however they came to see us and they showed us how it works, so now they buy all our old cooking oil, the whole lot, dirty, clean or whatever, they buy the whole lot and they go and recycle it and make it into biofuel for the aviation industry, so that's quite an exciting thing to be going on as well, so hopefully what we do in the resort can now benefit others

as well, and the environment which is obviously very important to everyone these days. And how can people get to you if they haven't been to Thailand before, and what's the nearest airport to you and how can they do that? Our nearest international airport obviously is Phuket, okay, Phuket Airport International is extremely local to the island, you all know already your biggest favourite is the Jetstar QR8, QR9, which comes in from Melbourne, we also have a Jetstar that comes in directly from Perth, which was launched last year, that's doing superbly well, and for those who are using the Perth flight, you'll also see Sea Breeze as one of the featured hotels on their holiday programme, which we're very pleased to tell you, we're actually the third best seller now for Phuket, which is fabulous. The old favourites, Thai International Airways, fly through Bangkok, connect very easily down to the island, Malaysian Airlines, and I think Aussie's favourite, the Singapore Airlines flights from all your major cities through Singapore, and Singapore Airlines itself has five flights, plus the Scoot flights, every day now from Singapore into Phuket direct, it's dead easy, instead of flying north and flying south, you're flying south and then come straight onto the island, so I think for the Australian, Singapore Airlines is one of the most preferred airlines.

For Phuket Airport now, you've got hundreds of choices of international flights, it really developed here last year, they did a massive renovation programme about three years ago, that's now in full operation, so you've got all the low-cost carriers, Scoot Airline as well apparently is quite popular into Australia as well, that obviously part of Singapore Airlines, that flies in as well, I suppose that's it really, but you've got good connectivity, and we also go the opposite way, so our favourites are there as well, so it's all good, it's a good way to get in. It's a beautiful resort, the Kata Sea Breeze Resort in Phuket, part of the Aksara Collection, and tell us a bit about that, the Aksara Collection. The Aksara Collection, the name itself actually comes from the names of the three daughters who own the company, our company is actually owned by a family of females, so we've got Mum as the Managing Director, who I work with directly obviously, looking after the company on her behalf, and then her three daughters, three daughters, the eldest one is called Kanakos, that's K-A, Aksara, Sa is the middle daughter, and Ra is the youngest daughter, so when I joined them, I thought we need to have a collection name, because they have three lovely properties, which are owned and managed by an all female group, so we came up with Aksara Collection, so it's actually the name of the family owners, which is quite nice, and very Thai, very Thai, which actually means infinity, Aksara, when they translated it before, it means infinity, so hopefully this family will go on for infinity, there you go.

The place is absolutely beautiful, Matthew, and it's Matthew Hindmarch, who is the Director of Hotels and Resorts at the beautiful Kata Sea Breeze, can you tell us how to see you online? We obviously were on Facebook, the name is Kata Sea Breeze, you'll find us, our second hotel, the Sis Kata, also is on Facebook, Instagram, both known by the name of the property, so they should be easy to find, however we have a, we're a member of a very special group, exclusive to Australia, which is called the Phuket Groupies Group, which is a closed group of 75,000 Australians, who only travel to Phuket, how about that, and we're a member of that group, it's

managed by three Australian ladies, it's a closed group, so you have to register and be certified by the three ladies, Linda is in charge, I think, and every year you'll see that we give away a seven-night holiday through the Phuket Groupies Group, Facebook Group, for a lucky winner from Australia to come and stay at the Sea Breeze, yeah, so I know you all love your social media in Australia, so you'll see us there as well, otherwise go to the website www.kataseabreeze.com and then you'll see all our photographs, and just click on our photo, and you can contact us directly, and I'm on there as well, so you'll be able to contact me through email directly, and it's Kata Sea Breeze, which is K-A-T-A Sea Breeze Resort in Phuket, you have a logo, breeze up your breezy day, fantastic logo, yeah, that came from one of our staff members, we had a competition about eight years ago, because I said we need a slogan, and the staff created breeze up your breezy day, there you go, I think that's a lovely slogan, especially at breakfast, yeah. Thank you so much for being on the program Matthew, and we recommend this hotel highly, the Kata Sea Breeze, and make sure you check it out when you're heading over to Phuket from Australia. Thank you very much, it was wonderful to meet you Geoff.